

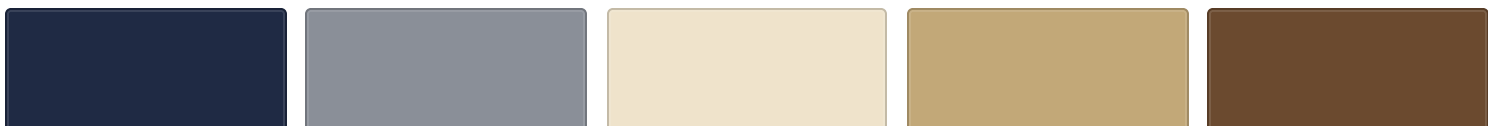
How to Dress for Nerds in DC

Classical menswear is a rules-based system, not a vibes game. Fit beats price; a five-color uniform beats a full closet; and three outfits cover almost everything Washington will ask of you. This is the 20% that does 80% of the work — distilled from a long dossier and five crash courses into something you can read in fifteen minutes and use for a decade.

AN 80/20 FIELD GUIDE · FOR THE POLICY-ADJACENT RESEARCHER HEADED TO DC · 2026



The whole thing in one sentence. Build a small uniform of well-fitting solids in five colors, learn three outfits, get everything altered — then stop thinking about clothes and go do the work.



Navy
workhorse

Mid-grey
workhorse

Cream
near the face

Tan
trousers, jackets

Brown
shoes, belts, leather

WHAT'S INSIDE

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PART 1

The Ten Rules

Everything below expands on these. If you read nothing else, internalize the list. They are not opinions — they are the compressed consensus of a century of tailored American menswear.

- 1 **Shoulders must fit. Do not negotiate.** Everything else can be altered; the shoulder cannot. If the shoulder is wrong, the garment is wrong — walk away.
- 2 **Show a quarter to half-inch of shirt cuff** past the jacket sleeve. It's the cheapest tell of a jacket that fits.
- 3 **The jacket hem bisects the distance** from the nape of your neck to the floor. Not the shrunken 2012 crop; not the 1990s drape.
- 4 **Mid-to-high-rise trousers** with any jacket, a slight break at the shoe, never flooding the cuff. This single proportion is the biggest "why does his look better."
- 5 **Shoe formality = trouser formality = jacket formality.** Don't cross rungs. Suede bucks don't go with a worsted suit; cap-toe oxfords don't go with chinos.
- 6 **Five colors: navy, mid-grey, tan, cream, brown.** No black daywear. Cream or light blue near the face, not bright white.
- 7 **Solids as the base.** Buy pattern through ties first, shirts second, jackets third, suits last.
- 8 **When you mix patterns, vary the scale** — a hairline stripe with a bold check, never two of the same width.
- 9 **Buy fewer, buy better, have everything altered.** An \$80 shirt tailored beats a \$300 shirt off the rack.
- 10 **No contrived "sprezzatura." No Windsor knots. No fun socks.** Effortlessness comes from fit and repetition, not from messing a detail up on purpose.

PART 2

Fit Is 80%

Fit — not price, not brand — is the single variable that separates "expensive" from "cheap." Get it right and almost nothing else has to be perfect; get it wrong and nothing else can save you.

A \$200 suit that fits beats a \$2,000 suit that doesn't.

THE FIRST PRINCIPLE OF DRESSING WELL

THE ONE THING YOU CAN'T FIX: SHOULDERS

The shoulder seam must end exactly where your shoulder bone ends. A divot or wrinkle at the sleevehead means the jacket is too big; X-shaped pulling means it's too small. Reshaping shoulders costs more than the jacket is worth and rarely works. **If the shoulders are wrong, put it back.**

THE COIN TEST

Stand naturally and slip a coin between the jacket collar and your shirt collar. If it falls through, the jacket is too big through the back and chest — not a cheap fix. A jacket should hug the back of your neck.

EVERYTHING ELSE IS CHEAP, SO ALTER IT

Sleeves are \$15–25. Trouser hems are \$10–20. A jacket waist can be suppressed; a shirt body can be taken in. Budget **\$60–120 of alterations into the price of every single thing you buy.** This is the highest-leverage money in your wardrobe.

The iron rule of tailoring: *An \$80 shirt altered beats a \$300 shirt off the rack, every time.* Cheap clothes that fit look expensive. Expensive clothes that don't fit look cheap.

PROPORTION IS THE SECRET UNLOCK

Low-rise trousers under a tailored jacket create an ugly triangle of exposed shirt and cut your leg line in half. Mid-to-high-rise trousers lengthen the leg, streamline the silhouette, and make the jacket look like it belongs to the outfit. It is the change that quietly makes a fit look "right" without anyone being able to say why.

PART 3

The Palette

Five colors. Every jacket, trouser, shirt, sweater, and shoe should pair with at least two others you already own. If a piece only works with one other thing, don't buy it — that's how closets fill up and still produce nothing to wear.



Navy and mid-grey are the workhorses — they do the most and offend no one. Mid-grey trousers in particular almost disappear, pairing cleanly with navy, brown, tan, and cream up top.

THREE HARD PROHIBITIONS

- **No black daywear.** Black is the most formal color there is (black tie is literally named for it), it washes out skin in daylight, and it doesn't sit cleanly next to navy. Black belongs to dress shoes with a dark suit, a single black knit tie, and the evening. Nowhere else by day.
- **Never tan shoes.** Pale shoes under dark trousers are flashlights — they pull every eye to your feet and away from your face. Dark brown or black, always.
- **Dark top, light bottom.** Navy or brown jacket over grey or tan trousers. The inverse — light jacket, dark trousers — visually cuts you off at the waist.

Black suits are for morticians and Model UN.

DEREK GUY

IF YOU'RE FAIR / LOW-CONTRAST

Pale skin with light or dirty-blond hair is "low contrast." Bright white right next to your face reads stark; **dial it down to cream or light blue** unless a dark suit and tie are framing it. Earth tones (olive, tobacco, camel, brown) beat jewel tones (emerald, sapphire) against fair coloring. The one exception worth keeping: *a quiet burgundy or oxblood note* — a knit tie, a scarf, an oxblood shoe — which fair complexions wear beautifully.

PART 4

The Three Outfits

These three cover roughly 95% of a working life in policy-adjacent DC. They share a tiny set of pieces, so the closet stays small while the registers stay distinct. Learn them, rotate within them, and you will look more put-together than nearly everyone in the room with a fraction of the effort.



1 · Smart Casual *the Tuesday uniform*

- SHIRT White or light-blue OCBD, tucked (sleeves rolled on a Friday)
- TROUSER Mid-grey wool, or tan chinos
- SHOES Brown penny loafers or dark-brown derbies
- LAYER Winter: navy crewneck over the shirt, collar peeking out

Why it works: the unfused oxford collar rolls softly and reads relaxed; grey anchors everything; brown leather against navy and grey is the quiet "blue-brown" warmth that looks expensive and tries nothing.

Signals: competent, here to work, not the story. If anyone comments on your clothes, you've mis-dialed.



2 · Business Casual *the DC uniform proper*

- JACKET Navy blazer (a navy suit jacket can stand in at first)
- TROUSER Mid-grey flannels
- SHIRT White or light-blue OCBD
- SHOES Brown derbies or loafers · brown belt
- OPTIONAL Navy grenadine or repp-stripe tie

Why it works: navy-over-grey is the archetypal sport-coat pairing, and brown shoes break up the navy-and-grey so you don't read "security guard" (navy jacket + navy trousers + black shoes). This one outfit covers about 70% of working days.

Signals: "I'm serious, but I'm not a lobbyist." A knit tie reads sartorial literacy; a repp stripe reads institutional DC.



3 · Full Suit *the meeting that matters*

SUIT	Navy worsted, matched, properly altered
SHIRT	White, semi-spread collar (<i>not</i> button-down with a suit)
TIE	Navy grenadine, four-in-hand, small dimple
SHOES	Black cap-toe oxfords · black belt
SOCKS	Over-the-calf, navy or charcoal

Why it works: navy is authority without arrogance — charcoal reads finance, black reads funeral. This is the one outfit where bright white is unambiguously right, because the dark suit and tie supply the contrast. Navy grenadine is the most versatile tie ever made.

Signals: testimony, briefing, first day, TV hit. Maximum competence, zero ambiguity.

The trick: all three are built from the same handful of pieces — OCBD, grey trousers, brown shoes, navy tailoring — reassembled into three formality registers. The closet feels almost too small. That is exactly the point.

PART 5

The Capsule, Item by Item

Five categories, each distilled to the handful of rules that matter and the one thing to buy first.



Shirts — the four inches that matter

The collar frames your face; that four inches does more work than the suit, the tie, or the shoes combined. Keep a five-shirt palette — white OCBD, light-blue OCBD, cream OCBD, blue university stripe, pink university stripe — and nothing else. Pinch the collar before you buy: soft and rollable is *unfused* (good); stiff as cardboard is *fused* (walk).

BUY FIRST A light-blue OCBD — the most flattering, most versatile shirt you can own. Buy two.



Shoes — Goodyear-welted or walk away

Welted construction is non-negotiable; everything glued is disposable. Two colors only — **dark brown** for daywear, **black** for the navy suit, never tan. This is the splurge slot, and the math justifies it: a \$900 welted shoe resoled over twenty years costs less per wear than \$150 shoes binned every two.

BUY FIRST Black cap-toe oxford (the suit needs it), then a dark-brown derby or penny loafer for everything else.



Belts — match the leather, carry a magnet

The belt leather matches the shoe leather: brown with brown, black with black. The entire quality test fits in your pocket — **solid brass is non-magnetic**. If a magnet snaps to the buckle, it's plated zinc that will wear through; put it back. Own two real belts, never one reversible.

BUY FIRST A brown leather belt, 1¼" wide, solid-brass buckle, burnished (not painted) edge.



Ties — your cheapest personality

This is where pattern belongs first: a tie is small, swappable, and the most concentrated signal you wear. **Navy grenadine is the single most versatile tie made** — start there, then a navy or burgundy knit, then a repp stripe. Real silk only (weight and a dry hand; polyester is slippery and glassy under the light). Four-in-hand knot with a small dimple — never a Windsor.

BUY FIRST A navy grenadine in the finer "garza fina" weave. It goes with everything.



Thrifting — often the only version now

Soft-shouldered American trad is mostly out of production, so the secondhand rack isn't the cheap option — it's frequently the only one. The math: a \$25 Goodwill Brooks Brothers tweed plus \$80 of tailoring beats an \$1,800 new equivalent and fits better. Rules: **natural fibers only** (wool, cotton, linen, silk, cashmere, leather — walk on polyester, "performance," "easy-care"), and **shoulders fit first**.

CARRY A tape measure, a small magnet, and your measurements on a card. That's the whole kit.

PART 6

The Shopping Roadmap

Order matters more than budget. Buy in this sequence and each purchase completes an outfit instead of sitting orphaned in the closet. Spend at the bottom of each range while you're learning; the pieces will still be correct in ten years.

#	BUY	BECAUSE IT UNLOCKS	TIER
1	Black cap-toe oxfords	The full-suit outfit — the one register you can't improvise	\$300–1,100
2	Mid-grey wool trousers	The navy-blazer / grey-flannel template — half your week	~\$150 + hem
3	Brown derbies or penny loafers	The second shoe that makes both casual outfits exist	\$150–700
4	White + light-blue OCBD	The four inches that frame your face (buy the pair together)	~\$200
5	Navy grenadine tie	The one essential tie; finishes the suit	\$30–200



Brown derbies



Light-blue shirt



Navy grenadine



Brown belt



Navy crewneck

Those five purchases — plus altering a suit you may already own — take you from "has a jacket and some shirts" to three complete, interchangeable outfits. **After that, in order of diminishing urgency:**

- Navy crewneck sweater → second trousers in tan or tropical wool → navy knit tie
- Proper brown *and* black leather belts (retire any reversible)
- Navy repp-stripe tie → a dedicated navy hopsack blazer (so the suit jacket stops doing double duty)
- Longer term: a mid-grey suit, a spring/fall jacket, suede chukkas, and one watch you actually want

PART 7

DC Specifics & the Don'ts

Washington is more conservative than New York or San Francisco, and its tailoring heritage is Ivy/trad American — soft, natural shoulders; Brooks Brothers and J. Press (which still has a store on L Street and dressed presidents from Roosevelt to the Bushes). That lineage, "softly-tailored American," is the register to write in.

Policy culture rewards understatement. Your clothes should say *look at the work*, not *look at me*. The reason senior people wear a narrow set of clothes over and over isn't a lack of taste — it's precisely the point. And mind the weather: DC summers are brutal and humid, so May through September means tropical wool, hopsack, and white shirts (colored ones show sweat; white hides it).

NEVER, IN DC

- Windsor knots (too symmetrical; reads car salesman)
- Fun or novelty socks
- Pocket squares as junior staff — reads like trying
- Sneakers with tailoring
- A watch worn over the shirt cuff
- Visible logos
- A black suit before 6pm, or unless someone is being buried

YOU CAN PERMIT YOURSELF

- OCBD sleeves rolled on a Friday
- A loose four-in-hand with a small dimple
- An open collar, no tie, when it's genuinely hot
- A knit tie instead of a silk one — always
- One quiet burgundy note: tie, scarf, or oxblood shoe
- Wearing the exact same three outfits on rotation, forever

None of this is doing *less* than the well-dressed people around you. It is doing exactly what the best-dressed men do — a small, deliberate uniform worn with confidence — just with less angst and a clearer head.

Build the uniform.
Iterate within it.
Stop thinking about clothes.

Three outfits, five colors, fit above everything. The rest is detail.

Distilled from a full menswear dossier and five crash courses (shirts, shoes, belts, ties, thrift). Principles drawn from Permanent Style, Put This On, Derek Guy, and a century of trad American tailoring. Share freely. · 2026